THE SHIFTING LABYRINTH

Project 4: Someone Else's Mechanics, Your Story / Found

Team 3 story checkpoint: October 26, 2026 | Implementation update: November 3, 2026

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Current playable build. A top-down 2D, single-explorer Godot game with three sectors, shifting passages, shrine checkpoints, armor and inventory, spirit combat, a sealed Minotaur encounter, and an Athena ending. The October 26 checkpoint was a design plan; this revision records what the repository now implements.

1. Premise | Rocklyn Clarke

A lone explorer travels through an enchanted Greek labyrinth with a small owl companion. The explorer clears bound spirits, follows changing routes through three sectors, defeats the Minotaur, and reaches the last shrine. Athena appears there, says she sent the explorer to end the curse, and offers a way home.

Major changes from the checkpoint

October 26 plan	Current build
Two switchable explorers, reunion, shared state	One playable explorer; no Q switch or reunion requirement
Partitions move between two fixed positions every 30 seconds	A network of passages opens and closes every 6 seconds
Minotaur is the last ordinary Heavy enemy	Boss room stays sealed until all 24 spirits fall; then the Minotaur hunts across the maze
Short fixed text plan with a 45-word count	Live objectives, maps, field guide, status text, and revised Athena dialogue

Current core loop

Use the map and gold route trail to find spirits; fight with the bow; collect supplies within a ten-slot limit; lock one passage with F; clear each sector and activate its shrine; defeat all 24 spirits to unseal the Minotaur; survive its pursuit; then reach the final shrine after defeating it.

Mechanic ownership remains as assigned: Rocky - shifting environment; Michael - utility/inventory; Zion - armor; Kai - enemy system. This update describes integration without reassigning their work.

2. Beats | Revised playable sequence

The original 15-beat outline described separation and reunion. These concise beats follow the solo campaign implemented now; they describe game events rather than claiming that every planned visual clue was built.

1. **Opening image.** A lone explorer enters a dim stone labyrinth while the owl follows.
2. **Theme.** The moving maze makes each route temporary; survival depends on reading and adapting to it.
3. **Setup.** The controls, field guide, minimap, route trail, inventory, bow, and first supplies establish play.
4. **Catalyst.** The first six-second wall cycle changes passages and makes the prison feel active.
5. **Debate.** Spirits, sealed gates, and limited healing make the first shrine a meaningful goal.
6. **Break into Two.** Clearing the first sector's eight spirits enables its shrine; activating it opens the next gate.
7. **B Story.** The owl stays with the explorer; its link to Athena is paid off at the end.
8. **Fun and Games.** The explorer holds passages, changes armor at shrines, and follows routes through shifting rooms.
9. **Midpoint.** The second shrine opens the route into the Bull Sanctuary; the horn icon shows the boss remains sealed.
10. **Bad Guys Close In.** The last sector adds more spirits while distant hoofbeats announce the Minotaur.
11. **All Is Lost.** The boss chamber remains physically shut while any spirit survives anywhere in the labyrinth.
12. **Dark Night.** The explorer can return to an activated shrine to change armor and manage healing supplies.
13. **Break into Three.** The 24th spirit's defeat opens the chamber and starts the Minotaur's persistent hunt.
14. **Finale.** The explorer defeats the Minotaur and reaches the now-ready final shrine.
15. **Final image.** Athena appears, explains the mission, and the victory screen reads 'The way home.'

> **Story scope.** The current game has no second explorer, reunion chamber condition, or Q-switching action. The owl is a cosmetic follower. Athena's appearance and dialogue are the implemented payoff; a separate home scene is not shown.

Sector sequence

Sector	Implemented role
Owl Galleries	First eight spirits and the first gate-opening shrine
Sunken Halls	Second group of eight spirits and the second shrine
Bull Sanctuary	Final eight spirits, sealed boss chamber, Minotaur, and Athena's shrine

3. A reason for every mechanic | Current build

Ancient masonry, shrines, owl imagery, spectral enemies, and the bull court still carry the Greek-labyrinth setting. The four systems retain their team owners, although the runtime rules below supersede some checkpoint assumptions.

Utility / Inventory | Michael Nearn

The ten-slot satchel limits how much armor, spare equipment, and healing relics the explorer can take from fallen challengers. E collects a whole item only when there is room. R consumes one relic for 25 health with a five-second cooldown. Activated shrines are the places to change armor or voluntarily drop supplies outside combat.

Armor Types | Zion King

Hare's Stride, Storm Vessel, and Bull's Stance are distinct worn suits with visible movement and combat feedback. Their speed, damage reduction, electrical resistance, and knockback tradeoffs make a shrine visit a tactical decision before the next sector or the Minotaur.

Shifting Environment | Rocky Clarke

The prison changes its routes every six seconds. The explorer can use F to hold one nearby, visible passage in its current open or closed state for ten seconds, followed by a five-second recharge. Amber warnings, cyan holds, map state, and route updates make changes readable; connectivity and occupant checks keep routes safe.

Enemy System | Kai Harris-Coles

Light and Heavy spirits guard the three sectors. The bow fires visible arrows, and spirits investigate, pursue, search, return, and navigate around current walls. Clearing each group unlocks a shrine and loot. The Minotaur keeps Heavy-class health and damage but gains a sealed chamber and a persistent whole-maze hunt after all 24 spirits are defeated.

> **Integration change.** One explorer now owns health, equipment, inventory, and cooldowns. The companion owl follows cosmetically. There is no active-character swap, second inventory view, or reunion trigger.

Implementation references

Primary gameplay: **scripts/game.gd**. Maze topology and tile collision: **scripts/maze_grid.gd**. Current player-facing summary: **README.md**. Focused checks: **tests/solo_regression.gd**, **tests/minotaur_regression.gd**, **tests/inventory_regression.gd**, and **tests/armor_regression.gd**.

4. Found moments | What the game currently shows

The October 26 checkpoint proposed matching charms, split footprints, an owl alcove, a convergence mural, broken shields, and a reunion. The current script does not place those as distinct scripted story set pieces. The implemented cues below are the evidence the player actually encounters.

Place or cue	What the player learns
Owl companion	An animated owl follows the lone explorer throughout the run and foreshadows Athena's final appearance.
Shifting sockets	Amber pulses warn of the next shift; cyan marks the passage held by F; dust marks a changed wall.
Challenger remnants	Scattered bones and loose armor show earlier travelers reached these rooms and left equipment behind.
Stone chests and shrines	A sealed chest opens after its sector is cleared; a glowing shrine then opens the next gate and becomes a checkpoint.
Bull court warning	Hoofbeats play near the final shrine while the living Minotaur is nearby; a gray horn marker shows the sealed boss.
Released Minotaur	The horn marker turns pink and tracks the moving boss; live guidance explains that it is hunting the explorer.
Final shrine	Athena appears beside the shrine after the boss falls; her two-line speech explains the mission and the victory screen offers the way home.

How story information reaches the player

The current build uses movement, enemy encounters, loot placement, world art, hoofbeat audio, map markers, a live objective, and short status messages. No journal, dialogue tree, or separate story-inspection button is required. The field guide and map add explicit guidance that the original checkpoint did not plan.

The generic floor and prop atlases supply visual detail, but the original named charm, footprint, mural, shield, and reunion sequence should remain labeled as planned concepts unless those exact placements are later implemented.

5. Shifting Environment | Implemented rules

Rule	Current implementation
World	162 chambers: 18 columns by 9 rows, 54 per sector, on a 109 x 55 grid of 64-pixel tiles. There are 297 passage connections.
Cadence	A global shift occurs every 6 seconds, with a 2-second amber warning. Each sector normally opens and closes up to 8 connections per cycle.
Wall model	Connections switch between open and closed. This replaces the checkpoint's two fixed physical positions no more than 5 feet apart.
Flashlight / F	Aim at a visible eligible passage within 3.048 world units. F holds its current open or closed state for 10 seconds; one hold is active at a time; a 5-second recharge follows.
Safe changes	Closures avoid the player, living enemies, and pickups. A proposed change is rolled back if it disconnects a sector or the last unlocked boundary route.
Protected gates	The outer boundary, locked sector gates, and sealed boss doors do not open through ordinary shifting or F.
Synchronized state	After a shift, the wall TileMap, collision and light occlusion, AStar navigation, map, and route guidance reflect the same passage layout.

Change to the design contract. The six-second open/closed passage system is a functional departure from the checkpoint's 30-second, two-position object movement. The ten-second hold and five-second cooldown remain, but F now locks a passage's present state instead of freezing a translated object.

Player-visible feedback

The minimap and full map use the current grid. A gold trail and compass text recalculate after shifts or enemy deaths. The field guide explains that F cannot unlock bronze gates or the sealed boss chamber. Map and guide overlays pause simulation while open.

6. Utility and Armor | Implemented rules

Ten-slot satchel and healing

The starting weapon, light armor, and two healing relics occupy five slots. Light, medium, and heavy armor cost 2, 3, and 4 slots; a weapon or relic costs 1. Equipped gear still counts. E can pick up anywhere if the whole item fits; a rejected item stays in the world. R consumes one relic to restore 25 health, capped at 100, and then waits five seconds. R has no effect at full health, without a relic, while dead, or during cooldown.

Sources and shrine permissions

Each sector places two relics, two loose armor remnants, and one sealed stone chest. The chest opens when every spirit in its sector is defeated. Each newly activated shrine grants a one-time armor reward; elite Heavy spirits also drop armor. Pickups do not auto-equip. At any previously activated shrine, outside combat, the explorer can equip armor or drop a selected spare item. The equipped suit and last weapon cannot be voluntarily dropped.

Armor effects

Suit	Damage / movement	Additional effect
Hare's Stride (light)	15% reduction; 4.4 units/sec	Animated sash and suit; 2 inventory slots
Storm Vessel (medium)	35% reduction; 4.0 units/sec	25% extra electrical resistance after general reduction; 3 slots
Bull's Stance (heavy)	60% reduction; 3.4 units/sec	No ordinary knockback; 4 slots

A 20-point physical hit deals 17, 13, or 8 with light, medium, or heavy armor. A 20-point electrical hit deals 9.75 with medium armor. Other ordinary hits push the explorer 0.5 unit unless heavy armor is equipped. Worn suit art follows movement and bow poses; the HUD icon and ring show the equipped type.

Death and restart

At zero health, the explorer respawns with 100 health at the most recent activated shrine, or at the entrance before any shrine. The equipped suit, weapon, and unused relics remain. Backup suits drop at the death position for later pickup. Healing cooldown resets, while defeated enemies, remaining enemy health, loot, and shrine progress persist. Restart restores the initial run, including loot and the boss seal.

7. Combat, progression, and the Minotaur

Bow and spirits

The explorer fires visible spectral arrows by holding left click. The reusable bow deals 25 damage, has a 0.5-second shot cooldown and a 10-unit maximum range, and uses no ammunition. Arrows launch from the drawn bow muzzle; wall and enemy segment collision resolves the nearest hit. Walls block shots, and aim must reach an enemy's body.

There are 24 spirits, eight in each sector, with Light and Heavy variants. Light spirits have 50 health and deal 10 damage; Heavy spirits have 100 health and deal 20. Selected Light spirits deal electrical damage. Spirits use idle, patrol, chase, search, return, and telegraphed attack states. They require line of sight to acquire the explorer, remember the last seen position, and recalculate AStar routes after shifts.

Checkpoint rule	Current runtime tuning
Detect within 6 units; leash at 10 units	Spirits detect with line of sight inside 8 units, remember the explorer for 7 seconds, then search and return. The game has no fixed 10-unit leash cutoff.
Light 4 / Heavy 2 units/sec; attacks every 1.5 / 3 sec	Chase movement is about 2.9 / 2.1 units/sec. Light / Heavy attack cooldowns are 1.1 / 2.2 sec after a 0.55 / 0.8 sec windup.

Boss seal and persistent hunt

The Minotaur's chamber is physically sealed in wall rendering, collision, and navigation until all 24 spirits across all sectors are defeated. F, shifting, and arrows cannot bypass it. The final spirit's defeat opens the three chamber passages and starts a hunt that targets the explorer across the full maze, even beyond normal spirit sight. The boss repaths after wall changes and after respawn; respawning does not reseal it. On the minimap and full map, its horns are gray while sealed, pink while hunting, and absent after defeat.

Shrines and ending

Clear a sector's enemies, then stand in its shrine outside combat to activate the checkpoint and open the next sector. The third shrine remains unavailable while the Minotaur lives. After the boss falls, reaching that shrine starts Athena's reveal and then the victory screen. Shrine activation itself does not heal the player.

8. Interface, text, and controls

The current interface uses a live objective, remaining-spirit count, compass route text, gold trail, minimap, full map, boss marker, inventory slots, armor protection/speed bars, and lock/heal cooldown indicators. H opens a field guide with the current rules. M opens the full map; G toggles the route trail. The map and guide pause game simulation.

Input	Current action
WASD / mouse	Move / aim
Hold left click	Fire repeated arrows
F	Hold one aimed nearby passage in its current state for 10 seconds
E / R	Pick up an item / consume one healing relic
Tab / X	Open inventory / drop selected spare at an activated shrine
M / G / H	Full map / route-trail toggle / field guide
Escape	Close an overlay or pause

Revised text status

The original 45-word planned count is no longer valid. Dynamic objectives, status messages, a map legend, armor labels, and the field guide add substantial visible text. A fresh assignment-specific word audit is needed before any claim that the current build meets the original 150-word limit. The current game has no Explorer B label or Q-switch instruction.

Athena's current caption and optional spoken line: 'I am Athena. I sent you here to end the Minotaur's reign. You broke the labyrinth's curse. Now I will bring you home.'

Current victory text: 'The way home.' The speech uses device text-to-speech only when available; the on-screen caption always supplies the line.

Build and verification basis

The repository includes a browser export workflow and local Godot project. This PDF revision was checked against the current scripts and README. Existing regression records cover 191 maze shifts, boss sealing and pursuit, inventory behavior, and armor effects; no gameplay source file was changed to make this document.

Source paths: scripts/game.gd; scripts/maze_grid.gd; README.md; tests/SOLO_VERIFICATION.md; tests/MINOTAUR_VERIFICATION.md; tests/INVENTORY_VERIFICATION.md; tests/armor_regression.gd. Read as of November 3, 2026.